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Beyond Justification

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CHAPTER 1

Liberating Paul's Gospel

Justification theory only then makes a relatively brief reappearance, Paul utilizing participatory arguments and presuppositions on both sides of this shorter discussion. How do we resolve the tensions here? We consider Philip Melancthon's famous solution in terms of a justification-sanctification sequence, but find it wanting. And our problems are only just beginning. In a later chapter we highlight the fundamental level at which the tensions between our opening account of the gospel and justification theory play out.

These tend to be glossed over but we need to face them squarely. Paul's theology is riven with the most profound fault-lines if both these theories of salvation stay in play. For the last fifty years Paul's interpreters have been carefully reexamining how he characterizes Jews because we have witnessed the horrors of the Holocaust. It has become apparent that not only was this an unprecedented attack on the existence of the modern Jewish people by a fundamentally Christian nation; it was rooted in centuries of Christian teaching.

The question is no longer merely academic.